# 1.3 Society and Religion

In New England, some African Americans performed tasks that were not available in other colonies—small consolation for their far-from-equal treatment.

**MAIN IDEA** New England was different from other colonial regions in terms of its use of enslaved labor and its religious views.

## ENSLAVED LABOR IN NEW ENGLAND

Enslaved African Americans accounted for only 2 to 3 percent of New England's population. But this wasn't really due to colonial opposition to enslavement. Some of the wealthiest New England merchants made their money in the slave trade. The low percentage was due to geography and economics. New England farms were generally small. Most colonial farmers had no need for large numbers of enslaved workers, and they couldn't afford them, anyway.

The enslaved African Americans who came to New England worked as household servants, farmhands, artisans, and laborers. In the Southern Colonies, slaveholders generally wanted to purchase enslaved people who could work in the fields immediately, but slaveholders in New England were often more willing to purchase young people who could be trained for specific household or business duties.

Enslaved people generally lived in their masters' houses and worked by their sides. They practiced carpentry, printing, baking, and making cloth, shoes, and clothing, among other trades. In seaport towns, enslaved African Americans sometimes worked alongside free African Americans in the shipyards and on the docks as fishers, whalers, and shipbuilders.

Some African Americans were born free, but most free African Americans spent part of their lives in enslavement. Some achieved freedom by fulfilling the terms of a work contract. Some escaped. Others were freed by their master for faithful service or as part of their master's will. Although both enslaved and free African Americans in New England enjoyed some legal rights, they were not treated equally. For example, a 1703 Massachusetts law stated that African Americans could not be outdoors after 9:00 P.M. unless they were on business for their masters.

## THE DECLINE OF PURITANISM

Some religious groups were treated unfairly, although not to the extent suffered by African Americans. The Puritans saw other Protestant groups, such as the Quakers and Baptists, as a threat to the harmony of their society. Therefore, Puritan leaders allowed only the male members of the Puritan church to vote and hold most public offices. Puritans clashed with other Protestant sects that disagreed with their teachings. They punished citizens who did not share their beliefs and even hanged several Quaker missionaries. They also objected to a newly emerging merchant class and its focus on commercial values and worried that the younger generation was only concerned with making money.

Beginning in 1650, membership in the Puritan church had begun to decline, especially among men. Quakers who had been deported from Massachusetts kept coming back. King Charles II of England sent a letter forbidding the execution of Quakers. Quaker communities and Baptist congregations began to flourish throughout New England.

The crown gave the Puritans two options: they could either obey the terms of the colonial charter of Massachusetts Bay or they could have the charter revoked. And the charter guaranteed **religious freedom**, or the right to practice the religion of one's choosing, for all.



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But the Puritan leaders believed themselves to be the highest authority in Massachusetts and did not feel that they answered to the king. Charles II disagreed. In 1684, the king canceled the colonial charter of Massachusetts Bay. Charles died in 1685, but that didn't do the Puritans any good. Charles's successor, James II, tried to strengthen English control even more. He combined Massachusetts with other northern colonies to form the **Dominion of New England**.

Eventually, the Dominion included Massachusetts Bay, Plymouth, New Hampshire, Maine, Rhode Island, Connecticut, New York, and New Jersey. Both the decision to create the Dominion and to appoint its new governor were extremely unpopular with the colonists. They felt stripped of the rights and freedoms they had enjoyed under their own colonial charters.

In 1691, Massachusetts received a new charter to replace the one King Charles had canceled. It guaranteed religious freedom for all Protestants, further undermining Puritan influence. It also opened up the right to vote to any man owning property, regardless of his religion. The number of property owners was much greater than the number of churchgoers. As a result, the charter led to a large increase in the number of voters in New England.

As Puritanism declined, education in New England was on the rise. Acquiring knowledge was becoming a new priority in the colony.



**New Britain Museum of American Art**
**New Britain, Connecticut**

In *Gentleman with Attendant,* painted between 1785–88, artist Ralph Earl characterizes the enslaved African Americans of New England as serving their masters more directly. This is in contrast to slavery in the Southern Colonies, where enslaved people worked in fields far from the owners, under the supervision of hired bosses.

## HISTORICAL THINKING

1. **READING CHECK** Why was the percentage of enslaved African Americans low in New England?
2. **IDENTIFY MAIN IDEAS AND DETAILS** What types of tasks did most enslaved and free African Americans in New England perform?
3. **ANALYZE CAUSE AND EFFECT** What impact did the 1691 Massachusetts charter have on Puritanism?



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